

26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia & Irmo, South Carolina

Welcome to our Carolina Cup guide. We put this together so everything about the weekend — travel, lodging, the venue, and what we're still waiting on from the tournament — lives in one place instead of scattered across emails and the group chat. As the tournament releases more information, we'll send updated versions of this same guide.

At a Glance

The one-minute version. If you read nothing else, read this.

Where	Polo Road Park 730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29223
When	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Bracket	Under 10 Boys Red Division
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min from Savannah
Hotel	Book from your team's list in Section 6 five hotels each, rates and drive times checked Sep 26
Do today	Book the hotel — hold a free-cancellation rate while you decide
Waiting on	Nothing — schedule, fields and complexes are confirmed

1. Tournament Quick Start

Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

Event	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Host	South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)
Team	Savannah United 16/17B Premier
Dates	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026

Venue	Polo Road Park 730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29223
Age Group	U10 • 7v7 format
Bracket	Under 10 Boys Red Division
Format	Group play → knockout rounds
Entry Fee	\$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)
Check-in	Online check-in only. There is no on-site check-in.
Stay-to-Play	Not published — see Section 6
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W
Parking	Free on-site at SCUFC complexes

2. Parent Action Items

DO THIS NOW

☐ Book your hotel

Rates re-checked live for October 2–4 on **September 26, 2026**, and every distance and drive time re-verified the same day with the Google Routes API. The schedule is published, so each team has **its own five-hotel list in Section 6** for its own complex — do not copy another team's list.

ACTION REQUIRED

☐ Complete online check-in

The accepted team list posted on September 14 and Savannah United 16/17B Premier is confirmed on it. SCUFC states that online check-in is open and that teams should start it **immediately**. There is **no on-site check-in** at this event, so this cannot be handled at the field. Re-verified September 18, 2026.

BRACKET POSTED — SEPTEMBER 16

☐ Know who is in your bracket

Our division is **Under 10 Boys Red Division**. Section 3 lists every team we could meet. The game-by-game schedule — pairings, kickoff times, fields and complexes — is published and verified; Section 5 has each family's departure time for every game.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. The live outlook puts the Midlands near 89°F Friday, 84°F Saturday and 72°F Sunday, with a 66% chance of showers and thunderstorms on Saturday and 84% on Sunday; the ten-year pattern swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers, heat gear and a rain shell.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Review the tournament rules

SCUFC has not published the 2026 rules document yet. Section 13 explains what we know and what we're still waiting on.

3. What We Know & What We're Waiting For

Confirmed

Official Tournament Information: 26th Annual Carolina Cup, October 2–4, 2026, hosted by South Carolina United FC in the Columbia/Irmo area of South Carolina.

Official Tournament Information: Open to boys and girls teams, U8 through U19, at Recreational, Intermediate, and Advanced levels. U8–U10 play 7v7.

Official Tournament Information: All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

Official Tournament Information: Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

Confirmed Team Information: Savannah United 16/17B Premier is accepted and scheduled to attend.

Pending Confirmation

Confirmed: Savannah United 16/17B Premier is on the official accepted team list (10U Boys). Online check-in is required — there is no on-site check-in.

Confirmed: our bracket is **Under 10 Boys Red Division** — 6 teams in total. Opponents in our division:

- BU10 Black (SC Surf)
- CESA U10B Pre ECNL-RL Summit-1
- JIYSC U10 Boys Red Roncancio
- SCUFC U10 Boys Blue
- SCUFC U10 Boys Red

Verified at the source on the tournament site. The game-by-game pairings, kickoff times and fields are published with the full schedule on September 26, 2026.

Confirmed now: The game schedule, opponents and field assignments are published and listed above.

Pending Confirmation: Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies. No policy has been published.

Pending Confirmation: The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule and tiebreakers.

Pending Confirmation: Coach instructions on uniform and any last team-specific details.

4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our U10 team will play 7v7.

Official Tournament Page (SincSports):

soccer.sincsports.com — [Carolina Cup](#)

Host Club:

southcarolinaunitedfc.com

Rules document:

Not published publicly for 2026. SCUFC keeps its event documents (rules, check-in, forms) in [SincSports Team Documents](#), which opens with a team login, and sends them to team managers — ask your team manager for the rules document.

Standings & tiebreak page:

soccer.sincsports.com — [Results Calculation](#)

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing re-verified September 18, 2026 (168.9 mi / 3h 12min, free-flow).

Scenario	Time	Notes
Free-flow driving	~3h 15min	Routing engine, no stops
With a fuel and rest stop	~3h 35min	Add ~20 min
Friday evening traffic	~4h 00min	Add ~45 min

Why the first number is the real one: the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

Player Report Time

Game	Kickoff	Arrive	Depart Savannah
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Saturday, October 3 vs Willex Football Academy U10 Field 8	11:45 AM EDT	11:00 AM	7:45 AM
Saturday, October 3 vs Queen City Mutiny U10 Gold Field 7	6:00 PM EDT	5:15 PM	2:00 PM
Sunday, October 4 vs TFC 16/17B Ibis I GA Field 3	9:15 AM EDT	8:30 AM	5:15 AM

Arrival is 45 minutes before kickoff. Departure is calculated from Savannah using the verified drive time of about 3h 15min (169 miles). If you are staying overnight near the venue, leave your hotel instead and ignore the departure column.

Parent Manager Recommendation: An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the pattern most traveling families use for this event.

6. Lodging

Official Tournament Information: our team plays at **Polo Road Park**, so this list is ranked by distance to *that* complex only. Each of our teams can be at a different complex, so do not copy another team’s hotel list. **5 of 5** hotels we verified fall inside our band (Primary 0–15 miles, Secondary 15–20 miles).

Inside the band — nearest first

Hampton Inn Columbia Northeast–Fort Jackson · Hilton

Distance:	4.9 mi / ~9 min to Polo Road Park · Primary
Rate:	\$337 per night · \$674 for two nights
Amenities:	Two-queen rooms, Free hot breakfast, Keeps Hilton points
Checked:	Distance verified 2026-09-28 in Google Maps

La Quinta Inn by Wyndham Columbia SE / Fort Jackson · Wyndham

Distance:	10.3 mi / ~14 min to Polo Road Park · Primary
Rate:	\$194 per night · \$388 for two nights
Amenities:	Free parking, Pet friendly, Breakfast included
Checked:	Distance verified 2026-09-28 in Google Maps

Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia SE (Exchange Blvd) · Choice

Distance:	10.3 mi / ~14 min to Polo Road Park · Primary
Rate:	\$122 per night · \$244 for two nights
Amenities:	Free breakfast, Free parking, Cheapest verified
Checked:	Distance verified 2026-09-28 in Google Maps

LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone · Hilton

Distance: 17.0 mi / ~20 min to Polo Road Park · Secondary
Rate: \$238 per night · \$485 for two nights
Amenities: Apartment-style suites, Kitchen in room, Keeps Hilton points
Checked: Distance verified 2026-09-28 in Google Maps

Hampton Inn Columbia I-26/Harbison Blvd · Hilton

Distance: 18.7 mi / ~22 min to Polo Road Park · Secondary
Rate: \$309 per night · \$618 for two nights
Amenities: Free hot breakfast, Pool, Keeps Hilton points
Checked: Distance verified 2026-09-28 in Google Maps

Distances are Google Maps driving distances from each hotel's verified street address to Polo Road Park, checked on the dates shown. Rates are the nightly price we last verified live and are **not** re-dated here — confirm the current price before booking. Absence from this list does not mean a hotel is sold out.

7. Weather & Heat Planning

Live forecast, fetched October 2, 2026 from the National Weather Service for Irmo / Columbia. Friday October 2: mostly sunny, high **89°F**, only a 4% chance of rain showers, 70°F overnight. Saturday October 3: high **84°F** with a **66%** chance of showers and thunderstorms — our busiest day, every team plays twice, with the storm risk climbing to 87% overnight. Sunday October 4: high **72°F** with an **84%** chance of showers and thunderstorms, 63°F overnight.

Longer-range pattern — ten-year observed, not a forecast

Afternoon high	Around 80°F on average — has reached 95°F
Morning low	Around 63°F — noticeably cool at the first game
Rain	Roughly a 1-in-6 chance of measurable rain on any given day
Sun	Strong — open complexes with limited shade
Best games	Morning games are meaningfully cooler than afternoon

What this means for packing

This is a two-wardrobe weekend. Bring the heat gear — water, electrolytes, sunscreen, cooling towels — but also bring a jacket or warm layer for early mornings and a rain shell, because October in the Midlands is not August. Start hydrating the day before travel.

Forecast rows: live National Weather Service outlook for Irmo / Columbia, fetched October 1, 2026. Pattern rows: ten years of recorded daily observations for Columbia, SC (Open-Meteo historical archive, 2016–2025) — a climatology, not a prediction. Re-check the forecast in the last 48 hours before travel.

8. Venue, Parking & Fields

Official Tournament Information: Our team plays at **Polo Road Park**, 730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29223. Below are all five SCUFC complexes in the area.

Ballentine Park Complex

1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063
Listed as the tournament's primary venue on the event listing.

SCUFC West Soccer Complex

1053 Bird Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Polo Road Park

730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29223

Southeastern Freight Lines Soccer Center

115 Sunbelt Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203

SV Presbyterian Church Fields

125 Sparkleberry Lane, Columbia, SC 29229

Parking

Cost	Free — SCUFC complexes have on-site parking
Fill time	Fills early on tournament mornings
Fields	Grass; specific field layouts published per complex by SCUFC
Amenities	Concessions and restrooms at the complexes
Tent policy	Pending Confirmation — not published

Official field layout — Polo Road Park

[Polo Road Park field layout \(2026 edition\) >](#)

2026 edition, published by SCUFC. Our fields (3, 4, 7 and 8) are the 7v7 blocks on this map.

Our fields: Field 8, Field 7, Field 3 — these are the labels to look for on site.

Drive to the gate: [Open in Google Maps >](#) — 730 Polo Road

Parent Manager Recommendation: Arrive 30–45 minutes before your first game to secure parking and walk to your field. These are large, spread-out complexes.

9. Team Communication Plan

Official schedule	SincSports (Carolina Cup)
Team updates	PlayMetrics Messages • Email
Tournament logistics	Parent Manager
Soccer questions	Coach
Urgent changes	Team chat / text

An updated guide will be sent as soon as the schedule is released.

10. Coach Updates (Coming Soon)

This section will be updated once our coaches release arrival times, uniform details, and any team-specific instructions.

Parents do not need to act on these items — they are for reference once confirmed by the coaching staff.

11. Player Guidance

Tournament weekends are exciting and demanding for young players. A few practical reminders.

- Prioritize sleep — early bedtimes Friday and Saturday
- Keep meals familiar — not the weekend for new foods
- Bring simple, preferred snacks
- Encourage steady hydration through the day
- Limit exhausting hotel-pool activity before games
- Bring quiet activities for downtime between games
- Expect physical and emotional fatigue
- Keep postgame conversations positive and brief
- Let coaches handle the soccer instruction
- Emphasize effort, teamwork, learning, and fun

12. Packing Checklist

Player Gear

- ☐ Both uniform kits
- ☐ Cleats
- ☐ Shin guards
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Warm-up / training gear
- ☐ Dry clothes
- ☐ Recovery shoes or sandals
- ☐ Personal medications
- ☐ Warm layer for early games

Weather & Hydration

- ☐ Water (plenty)
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Sunscreen (SPF 50+)
- ☐ Cooling towel
- ☐ Rain gear / shell
- ☐ Small fan
- ☐ Plastic bags for wet gear
- ☐ Extra blanket or jacket

Parent Sideline

- ☐ Folding chairs
- ☐ Umbrella
- ☐ Cooler
- ☐ Snacks
- ☐ Portable charger
- ☐ Wipes
- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Activities for siblings
- ☐ Cash for concessions
- ☐ Shade if permitted

Emergency

- ☐ Basic first-aid supplies
- ☐ Ice packs
- ☐ Insurance information
- ☐ Emergency contacts
- ☐ Prescriptions

13. Tournament Rules

Pending Confirmation

SCUFC has not published the 2026 Carolina Cup rules document. Game length, mercy rule, substitution rules, and the tiebreaker order are all still unconfirmed for this year. **We will not guess at these.** As soon as the rules are published we'll add the full breakdown — including the complete tiebreaker hierarchy — to this section and resend the guide.

What we do know

Format	7v7 for U8–U10 age groups
Age groups	U8–U19, boys and girls
Levels	Recreational, Intermediate, Advanced
Sanctioning	US Youth Soccer affiliated (SC Youth Soccer)
Check-in	Online only — no on-site check-in

How group ties are decided

Group play is decided on points. The tournament's own results page states that where teams finish level on points it applies its tiebreaker rules in order until the tie is broken, and that anything still level is broken manually by the tournament director. **The tiebreaker order itself is only published on that page once games have been played**, and the event's rules document sits behind the team login in SincSports Team Documents — so this guide does not print an order borrowed from other events. Check it directly: [live standings & tiebreak page](#) ›

Rules questions: Tournament Director Tripp Miller — tripp@scufc.com

Bracket questions (U8–U12): Jamie McClendon — jamie@scufc.com

14. Nearby Family Resources

Food and errands for **this team's own complex** — every distance below is measured from the field gate, nearest-first, verified with the Google Routes API. The essentials lists further down were measured from Ballentine Park; if this team is not at Ballentine, use the map link at the top of this guide rather than those distances. Restaurant and rating data checked September 28, 2026.

Where to eat — five for Polo Road Park

Saturday's break is about 4h25m, the longest of the four teams, so the sit-down options are realistic — Luca's is a minute from the park if you want the fast version instead.

Luca's Wood Fire Pizza & Restaurant · Pizza Restaurant

0.3 mi / ~1 min from Polo Road Park · 4.6★ (559 reviews)

Why: Closest food to the park — wood-fired pizza, walk-in friendly.

843 Polo Rd suite 4, Columbia, SC 29223, USA

[Directions >](#)

Little Pigs Barbecue · Barbecue Restaurant

2.7 mi / ~6 min from Polo Road Park · 4.5★ (3147 reviews)

Why: South Carolina barbecue institution; fast counter service, big local favourite.

4927 Alpine Rd, Columbia, SC 29223, USA

[Directions >](#)

J.R. Cash's Grill and Bar · Bar & Grill

2.9 mi / ~7 min from Polo Road Park · 4.3★ (2379 reviews)

Why: Family grill for a sit-down meal when there is time to spare.

111 Sparkleberry Crossing Rd #11, Columbia, SC 29229, USA

[Directions >](#)

Tacos Nayarit · Mexican Restaurant

4.4 mi / ~8 min from Polo Road Park · 4.6★ (3217 reviews)

Why: Best-reviewed Mexican near the park; quick, cheap, kid-friendly.

1531 Percival Rd, Columbia, SC 29223, USA

[Directions >](#)

Pho Viet · Vietnamese Restaurant

2.9 mi / ~5 min from Polo Road Park · 4.2★ (901 reviews)

Why: Quick noodle bowls, not fried — good between games and easy on the stomach.

9308 Two Notch Rd, Columbia, SC 29223, USA

[Directions >](#)

Distances measured from the field to each address with the Google Routes API; ratings are Google's as at the time of checking (2026-09-28). A restaurant that is not listed here

is not a judgement on it — it just was not among the five closest that fit a family weekend.

Closest to Polo Road Park (730 Polo Road)

Straight-line errands from this team's own complex, measured 2026-09-28 with the Google Routes API. Distances are door-to-door driving miles, not estimates.

Urgent care	Novant Health Urgent Care – Northeast (Formerly Doctors Care) 10040 Two Notch Rd, Columbia, SC 29223 (803) 788-1153 Walk-in clinic on Two Notch Rd with X-ray on site. 2.5 mi · 5 min drive 4.4★ (877) Directions >
Pharmacy	Walmart Pharmacy 10060 Two Notch Rd, Columbia, SC 29223 (803) 699-1100 Walmart Pharmacy inside the Two Notch Rd store; Walgreens (9001 Two Notch Rd) is 3.6 mi. 3.0 mi · 7 min drive 3.8★ (28) Directions >
Grocery	Publix Super Market at North Pointe Shopping Center 10128 Two Notch Rd, Columbia, SC 29223 (803) 788-9484 3.0 mi · 7 min drive 4.5★ (1,686) Directions >
Big-box store	Walmart Supercenter 10060 Two Notch Rd, Columbia, SC 29223 (803) 736-8123 Walmart also covers pharmacy and sporting-goods basics. 3.0 mi · 7 min drive 3.8★ (5,857) Directions >
Coffee	Dutch Bros Coffee 9349 Two Notch Rd, Columbia, SC 29223 (877) 899-2767 2.9 mi · 5 min drive 4.0★ (89) Directions >
Sporting goods	Academy Sports + Outdoors 730 Fashion Dr, Columbia, SC 29229 (803) 462-6340 Full sporting-goods store across from the Village at Sandhill. 4.3 mi · 10 min drive 4.3★ (2,024) Directions >
Hospital ER	MUSC Health Columbia Medical Center Northeast 120 Gateway Corporate Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203 (803) 865-4500 MUSC Northeast emergency department - use this, not an urgent care, for anything serious. 6.3 mi · 10 min drive 2.8★ (221) Directions >

15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, October 2

Travel day for most families. Leave Savannah by early afternoon — about 3h 15min in free-flow conditions.

Saturday, October 3 — Group Play

11:45 AM EDT vs Willex Football Academy U10 • Field 8 — arrive 11:00 AM

6:00 PM EDT vs Queen City Mutiny U10 Gold • Field 7 — arrive 5:15 PM

Sunday, October 4 — Group Play

9:15 AM EDT vs TFC 16/17B Ibis I GA • Field 3 — arrive 8:30 AM

Between-Games Rhythm

Saturday is an 11:45 AM and 6:00 PM double at Polo Road — the biggest gap of our four teams at roughly 4 hours 25 minutes. That is long enough to leave the complex, eat a proper meal and rest before coming back for the evening game.

Final whistle ~12:50 PM

After game #126 on Field 8.

Lunch inside 30 minutes 1:15 PM

Eat properly close to the whistle. Northeast Columbia has the widest choice — the Fort Jackson/Polo Road area is a short drive.

Hotel or A/C rest 2:00 PM

This is the game where a hotel room pays off: two hours out of the heat with feet up before the evening kickoff.

Cool down + change kit 3:30 PM

Fresh shirt and socks. Evening games at Polo Road carry humidity once the sun drops.

Eat again, light 4:15 PM

Small carbohydrate snack + electrolytes about 90 minutes before kickoff — not a full meal.

Back for game #128 5:15 PM

Field 7. Traffic on Two Notch Road builds after 5:00 PM.

16. Quick Reference

Screenshot this for game day.

Tournament	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Team	Savannah United 16/17B Premier
Dates	Oct 2–4, 2026
Venue	Polo Road Park • 730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29223
Schedule	Posted Sep 26, 2026 — verified
Drive	~169 mi • ~3h 15min

Hotel	See your team's list in Section 6
Format	U10 • 7v7
Check-in	Online only — no on-site check-in
Weather	Fri 90° / Sat 84° / Sun 72°F • rain likely
Director	Tripp Miller • tripp@scufc.com
SCUFC	877-457-2832

17. Final Next Steps

- 1. Book your hotel now.** The Irmo area was 80% booked when we checked. A free-cancellation rate costs nothing to hold.
- 2. Complete online check-in now if you have not already.** There is no on-site check-in at this tournament.
- 3. Game times, fields and complexes are published and verified.** Section 5 has your departure time for every game.
- 4. Pack for two climates** — cool mornings, warm afternoons, and a real chance of rain.
- 5. Re-check the forecast** in the last 48 hours before travel — the weekend is trending wetter.

Go, SU 16/17B Premier!

Looking forward to a great weekend in Columbia. Safe travels — and we'll send any last change straight to you.